CSE0001 — DIGITAL LITERACY

Digital Literacy

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Introduction

Honestly, when I first heard the phrase 'digital literacy,' I assumed it just meant knowing how to use a smartphone or send an email. But working through this project changed that perspective pretty quickly.

This project is built around the role of a Student Digital Ambassador — someone who doesn't just use technology, but understands it well enough to help others use it smarter and safer.

The goal was to build a Digital Literacy Portfolio that actually meant something: covering online safety, professional communication, and making the most of the digital platforms we already use every day.

Across five tasks, I got hands-on with things I'd either never tried before or had been doing without really thinking about — from designing an infographic to exploring cybercrime cases to setting up a proper professional profile online. Each task pushed me to engage with a different side of what it means to be digitally literate.

Looking back, this project wasn't just about picking up technical skills. It was about developing a more thoughtful and responsible relationship with the digital world — which, whether we like it or not, is the world most of us already live in.

Task 1 — Presentation

Creating a Digital Literacy Awareness Infographic

For this task, I designed a digital literacy awareness infographic using Canva. I went with a vertical layout because it just feels more natural to read — it flows the way your eye already moves down a screen.

The content I included covered what digital literacy actually means, safe internet habits, useful tools for students, and the basics of email etiquette. My goal was to keep it clear enough that someone could glance at it and immediately understand the message — no dense paragraphs, no jargon.

What surprised me most was how much the visual side of things actually mattered. Swapping out a plain bullet list for the right icon or adjusting the colour palette completely changed how the information felt to read. It made me realise that how you present something is almost as important as what you're saying.

That said, getting the balance right wasn't easy. Choosing colour combinations that looked good together while still being easy to read took a few rounds of adjustments. Spacing was tricky too — too tight and it felt cluttered, too loose and it looked unfinished.

By the end of it, I came away with a better sense of both design thinking and how to communicate information effectively to a general audience.

Task 2 — Portfolio

Building a Professional Online Presence

For this task, I set up profiles on GitHub and LinkedIn — two platforms I'd heard about constantly but never actually taken seriously until now.

GitHub made immediate sense to me. As someone studying cybersecurity, having a place to store, organise, and share my coding work is genuinely useful — not just for assessments, but for showing people what I'm actually capable of over time. It's like a living record of your technical growth.

LinkedIn felt a bit more unfamiliar at first. Setting up a professional profile as a first-year student, when you don't have a long list of experiences to show, felt a little awkward. But I came to understand that starting early is the whole point. I added my academic background, a brief note on what I'm working towards, and started connecting with a few peers and seniors.

What this task really drove home was how much your online identity matters — even before you graduate. Recruiters look at these profiles. Opportunities come through these networks. The version of you that exists online is often someone's first impression of you.

My plan going forward is simple: keep GitHub updated with real projects, and stay genuinely active on LinkedIn — not just scrolling, but actually engaging with content and people in my field.

Task 3 — Platforms and Coding

Google Forms and HackerRank

This task split into two parts, and they were quite different from each other — which actually made it more interesting.

On Google Forms, I built a Digital Literacy Awareness Quiz for my classmates. It was the first time I'd really explored the platform beyond just filling in a form someone else had made. Setting answer keys, linking responses to a spreadsheet, mixing question types — it opened my eyes to how genuinely powerful a free tool like this can be for collecting and making sense of data. I can already see myself using it for group projects and research tasks down the line.

On HackerRank, I worked through some basic coding problems. Nothing advanced — but that was kind of the point. What I found most valuable wasn't solving the problems themselves, it was the discipline of writing clean, structured code rather than just code that works. There's a difference, and this platform made me feel that difference.

Together, these two platforms cover very different sides of what it means to be digitally capable — one is about organising and communicating information, the other is about building the logical foundation that a lot of technical work sits on. Both feel relevant to where I'm headed.

Task 4 — Emails and Etiquette

When a Small Mistake Becomes a Big Problem

This task was grounded in a situation that probably sounds familiar to most students.

A student sent an assignment to their professor over email — in a hurry, without double-checking. No attachment. No clear subject line. Just a rushed message that looked incomplete. The professor, receiving dozens of emails, didn't follow up on it. The deadline passed. The student only realised what had happened after the fact.

It's such a small thing. And yet the consequences — confusion, stress, a missed deadline — were very real.

What I took from this is that email etiquette isn't really about being formal for the sake of it. It's about respect for the other person's time and making sure your message actually does what you need it to do. A clear subject line tells the reader what to expect. Checking for attachments before hitting send takes ten seconds. Reading back through an email before you send it costs you maybe a minute.

These are small habits. But in a professional or academic context, they're the difference between being taken seriously and being overlooked.

Task 5 — Cybercrime and Prevention

What Actually Surprised Me About How These Scams Work

Before this task, I think I had a fairly cinematic idea of what cybercrime looked like — complex code, dark screens, people bypassing security systems. What I actually found was both simpler and more unsettling than that.

Most of the scams I researched — phishing emails, fake UPI collect requests, fraudulent QR codes — don't rely on technical genius at all. They rely on human behaviour. On urgency. On the fact that most of us don't pause to verify something that looks official and feels time-sensitive.

The UPI scams particularly stood out to me. The idea that someone could lose real money simply by approving a notification they didn't fully read — that felt close to home. These aren't things happening to careless people. They happen to informed, educated individuals who were just moving too fast in that moment.

This research genuinely changed something for me. I've started being more deliberate about how I handle online payments and unfamiliar links. Before I act on anything — a payment request, a link, a message asking me to verify something — I pause and check. It takes a

few extra seconds. But given what I now know about how these scams work, those seconds feel very much worth it.

Conclusion

If I had to sum up what this project gave me, it wouldn't just be a list of skills. It would be a shift in how I think about being online.

I came in knowing how to use digital tools. I'm leaving with a better understanding of how to use them well — thoughtfully, safely, and in a way that actually serves me rather than just filling time. Whether that's writing a professional email, maintaining a GitHub profile, staying alert to a suspicious payment request, or designing something that communicates clearly — all of it connects back to the same core idea: being digitally literate isn't a one-time thing. It's an ongoing practice.

The task I'll probably carry with me longest is the cybercrime research — not because it was the most technical, but because it was the most personal. It made me genuinely more careful. And in a world where one unguarded click can cause real damage, that feels like the most valuable thing this project could have given me.

I'm leaving this project more aware, more prepared, and honestly, more curious about the field I've chosen to study.

References

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